

widget, but with a different interface.

When you launch an application, it uses the entire screen—it does not even waste space for a title bar. There are no window control buttons and the activity bar is hidden. As in the case of MeeGo, moving the mouse pointer against the upper edge of the screen displays the activity bar. The right-hand corner has an 'X' button to close the window. You can select the search and launch button to choose an alternate application.

Clicking on the icon of the active application on the activity bar displays a list of the running applications, and you can switch to any. The usual desktop short-cuts like *Alt-Tab* may also be used.

A nice way of switching between running applications is by using active screen edges. It worked on Kubuntu Netbook 9.04; however, I could not get it to work on the current version of Arch Linux. Still, the Plasma netbook interface is evolving. We will wait and see.

The use of the full screen without even the title bar, as seen in the image, appealed to me a lot.

Ubuntu Netbook

Ubuntu's new Netbook edition continues to use a panel on the top. In addition, it uses a vertical launcher on the left side. Since netbooks come in a wide-screen format, this is not a bad idea. The vertical application launcher is to keep icons of commonly used applications. It is similar to the dock bar of Mac OSX. When an application is launched, an icon is added to the vertical bar. You can keep it in the dock to be used in future conveniently. Clicking on an icon starts the application, or brings it to the foreground, if it is already running. The icons are large enough to be useful with a touch screen.

The use of the panel on the top is interesting (Figure 3). The status information about the machine is retained. Icons for controlling the active window are displayed in the same panel. For the standard GNOME and KDE applications, the menu bar is also displayed in the panel, as the Konqueror example shows. However, the menu bars of applications like Firefox and OpenOffice are not extracted and displayed in the panel. I am not sure whether this is a current limitation, or cannot be avoided. Chrome does not have a menu bar.

I found this interface offered the least surprises to a desktop user.

Verdict?

Each OS interface includes searching for an application to start it. Each offers a chance to store commonly used applications for convenient access. And each offers the applications in logically

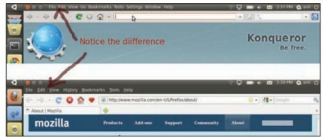


Figure 3: Ubuntu Netbook: The difference in the panel: a. Konqueror is active, b. Firefox is active

defined groups as well, like a traditional menu.

It is tough to decide. I could use and switch between the three with little difficulty. Ubuntu Netbook offers the easiest way to start a 'favourite' application. It is also the simplest for switching between active applications. A Linux desktop user is likely to feel comfortable with the Ubuntu Netbook edition.

The MeeGo interface seems remarkably streamlined. Even the top bar does not overwhelm a user with tightly packed information. It is difficult to imagine even a novice getting confused by it (except if games do not use all the available screen space).

Unlike Ubuntu and KDE, MeeGo shows the title bar of an application. I found the missing title bar disconcerting in the beginning, on KDE in particular, but got used to it quickly. However, I can imagine a user finding it difficult when selecting an application window from a list.

KDE's Plasma netbook packs the power of KDE applications. The interface is sleek, simple and attractive. There's a wealth of KDE add-ons available and 'live' applications can be pinned to 'Page One'. Personally, I may not use any of the add-ons, but I am likely to use the KDE netbook interface as the default. I find that the full-screen mode for applications minimises distractions, especially when reading or viewing media. I have always liked the full-screen interface of Sugar (OLPC).

Switching between application windows was the hardest with KDE. It would be nice if it was as easy as on Sugar—at the press of a function key.

Currently, I expect to keep each of the three installed, and keep them updated. Maybe, after a year, one will become my definite favourite. **END** 

About Anil Seth

The author works as a consultant, prior to which he was a professor at Padre Concoicao College of Engineering (PCCE) in Goa, managed IT and imaging solutions for Phil Corporation Limited (Goa), supported domestic customers for Tata Burroughs/TIL, and was a researcher with IIT-K and the Indian Institute of Geomagnetism (Mumbai). You can find him online at <http://sethanil.com> and reach him via email at anil@sethanil.com.